ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Can You Learn to Be a Prophet?

Derech Hashem 3:4:1-4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 4, paragraphs 1-4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 13 December 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

Chapter 4 is called "the experience of being a prophet". The ladder so far: dreams; then God's names and the angels; then Ruah HaKodesh, an experience in which certain knowledge is given; and above it nevuah. A participant gave the definition: an intense connection with the divine. Messages for others are incidental. During that connection the prophet is given perceptions about the world and about God; his body stops functioning, and when he wakes the vision is translated back into knowledge. Now the Ramhal goes into detail.

Paragraph 1: no doubt at all

A true prophet attains what he is given with full understanding. He has no doubt about any aspect of it: where it came from, or what it means. "If you have any doubt whether you're a prophet or not, you're not a prophet." Something that simply fell into your mind is more likely the kind of Ruah HaKodesh we discussed; prophecy is an intense experience of connection, and the prophet is completely certain of it.

A participant observed that almost all our knowledge is subjective, and this is the one thing a person knows absolutely. Another asked whether someone could still deceive himself, for example a person who falls to the floor in prayer. The Rabbi agreed that the mind can do anything, said "that's not prophecy", and noted that there are other tests of a true prophet which will come later.

He pointed to Avraham at the Akedah: he could go to sacrifice his son only because he knew for certain. "If the Kadosh Barukh Hu came to you in a dream, if you had a dream every night, would you go and kill your son?"

Shemuel and Eli

The story of young Shemuel: God calls him at night, and he runs to Eli, "Did you call me?" This happens three times, because, as the pasuk says, Shemuel had not yet known prophecy. The third time Eli understands, and tells him to lie down, prepare himself, and answer "Speak, for Your servant is listening."

Prophecy is a discipline. It is a mistake to think one becomes a prophet once and for all. Most prophets fluctuated: an hour of prophecy one day, ten minutes another, nothing for a week. They had teachers and tutors, "the world university" of prophecy. A participant asked who taught Avraham. The Rabbi: Avraham discovered God himself. Some geniuses learn without teachers, but it is much harder.

Paragraphs 2-3: step by step

No one reaches prophecy in one go. A person ascends level after level, with much training, as in every discipline. This is the meaning of the "Bnei HaNeviim", the students of the prophets found throughout Nakh, who stood by the prophet and learned from him.

A person may also have a revelation without recognising it as prophecy, thinking it is something natural, until the full prophetic energy comes. That is exactly what happened to Shemuel. He heard what sounded like Eli's voice, though there were no sound waves in the room; God placed it in his mind. The fact that he ran shows he was not yet in the full experience. Eli's instruction to lie down and focus is "mindfulness to a very intense level": switching off everything, which the Rambam lists as one of the qualities of a prophet.

The same at the burning bush. Moshe, aged eighty, thinks there is simply a bush on fire. The Midrash says God first spoke to him in the voice of his father Amram; perhaps, the Rabbi suggested, to put him at ease. Only later does the real prophecy begin.

Paragraph 4: how prophets trained

Those training for prophecy used particular practices to draw down the energy. The aim is to weaken the hold of the body, because every soul is in a sense a prophet, and only the body holds it back. Their methods included kavanot and meditation, mentioning holy names, and songs into which God's names are woven.

His example is *Ana BeKhoah*, said every morning in Shahrit: a simple-sounding prayer with deep names hidden in its initial letters. The old Iraqi custom was to stand for it. The many piyyutim of the Rishonim, and most of the Selihot we say, come from the same recognition that composing and singing songs is a way of attaching to the divine.

As they become more refined, they draw nearer to God until they reach full prophecy. The experienced prophet teaches the students how to sustain and enlarge their first glimpses: "You heard a voice, it wasn't intense enough, you should have focused more." The Rabbi compared it to the teacher in *The Karate Kid*. And he recalled the idea that expertise in anything takes some ten thousand hours.

A participant asked how imperfect people could connect at all, and pointed to Bilam. The Rabbi said no human being is perfect, not even Moshe, and asked him to keep the question about Bilam for paragraphs 10 and 11.

Each prophet has his style

Every prophet's experience is coloured by who he is. Experts can tell a passage of Yeshayahu from one of Yehezkel. Hazal say that in Sefer Devarim we hear Moshe's own voice, which is why its style is so different, more flowing and emotional, a difference that Spinoza and later Bible

critics seized on. Like a boy reading the parashah: same words, same taamim, yet you can tell who taught him. A participant summed it up: the experience was the same, but the way it is expressed is coloured by the person.

Summary

- A true prophet has absolutely no doubt that he is prophesying.
- Prophecy is a discipline learned step by step, usually with a teacher.
- First experiences, like Shemuel's call and Moshe's bush, may not be recognised as prophecy.
- Training involved meditation, holy names and song, all aimed at loosening the body's hold.
- Each prophet expresses his prophecy in his own style.

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